

Heart of the Blessed Lady, the Perfection of Wisdom

Bhagavatī Prajñāpāramitā Hṛdaya · Toh 21 · Derge Kangyur

བཅའ་ལཱ་འདས་མ་ཤེས་རབ་ཀྱི་རལ་ཏུ་ཕྱུག་པའ་སྒྲིག་པོ།

Toh 21 in the Kangyur is the Heart Sūtra, known in Sanskrit as the Bhagavatī Prajñāpāramitā Hṛdaya and in Tibetan as the Bcom ldan 'das ma shes rab kyi pha rol tu phyin pa'i snying po, meaning "The Heart of the Blessed Lady, the Perfection of Wisdom." It is one of the most celebrated and widely recited texts in all of Buddhist literature, belonging to the Prajñāpāramitā, or Perfection of Wisdom, class of sūtras, and it distills the vast teachings on emptiness and wisdom into a remarkably compact form. The text presents the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara's insight into the emptiness of the five aggregates, culminating in the famous mantra that encapsulates the path to liberation. As a sūtra attributed to the speech of the Buddha, it belongs to the Kangyur, the Tibetan canonical collection of translated words of the Buddha, and sits within the broader Prajñāpāramitā section of that canon.

Revised and definitively established.

In the language of India: Bhagavatī Prajñāpāramitā Hṛdaya. In the language of Tibet: The Heart of the Blessed Lady, the Perfection of Wisdom. This constitutes one fascicle.

Homage to the Blessed Lady, the Perfection of Wisdom.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling at Rājagṛha, on Vulture Peak Mountain, together with a great assembly of monks and a great assembly of bodhisattvas. At that time the Blessed One entered into meditative absorption on the enumeration of Dharma called "Profound Illumination." Also at that time, the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara was surveying the very practice of the profound Perfection of Wisdom, and he looked upon those five aggregates as well, seeing them to be empty of inherent existence.

Then, through the power of the Buddha, the venerable Śāriputra said this to the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara: "How should a son of good family or a daughter of good family who wishes to practice the practice of the profound Perfection of Wisdom train?"

When he had spoken thus, the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara replied to the venerable Śāradvatīputra in these words: "Śāriputra, a son of good family or a daughter of good family who wishes to practice the practice of the profound Perfection of Wisdom should look upon things in this way: they should look perfectly and correctly upon those five aggregates also as empty of inherent existence.

Form is empty. Emptiness is form. Emptiness is not other than form; form is not other than emptiness. Likewise, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are empty.

Śāriputra, therefore, all phenomena are emptiness: without characteristic, unborn, unceased, unstained, not free from stain, not diminished, not filled.

Śāriputra, therefore, in emptiness there is no form, no feeling, no perception, no formations, no consciousness; no eye, no ear, no nose, no tongue, no body, no mind; no form, no sound, no smell, no taste, no tactile object, no mental object. There is no eye element, and so on up through no mind element, no element of mental consciousness. There is no ignorance, no exhaustion of ignorance, and so on up through no aging and death, no exhaustion of aging and death. There is no suffering, no origin, no cessation, no path. There is no wisdom, no attainment, and no non-attainment.

Śāriputra, therefore, because bodhisattvas have nothing to attain, they rely upon and abide in the Perfection of Wisdom, and with no obscuration in the mind they are without fear. Having utterly transcended error, they reach the end of nirvāṇa. All buddhas dwelling throughout the three times, relying upon the Perfection of Wisdom, have fully and perfectly awoken to unsurpassed, complete, and perfect awakening.

Therefore, one should know the mantra of the Perfection of Wisdom, the mantra of great knowledge, the unsurpassed mantra, the mantra equal to the unequaled, the mantra that completely pacifies all suffering — because it is not false, it is to be known as true. The mantra of the Perfection of Wisdom is spoken thus:

tadyathā — gate gate pāragate pārasaṃgate bodhi svāhā.

Śāriputra, the bodhisattva, the great being, should train in the profound Perfection of Wisdom in this way."

Thereupon the Blessed One arose from that meditative absorption,

and praised the noble bodhisattva, the great being Avalokiteśvara, saying "Excellent!" Then he declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, it is just so. Noble son, it is just so — one should train in the profound Perfection of Wisdom exactly as you have taught it. The Tathāgatas too rejoice in this."

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the venerable Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara, and the entire assembled retinue, together with the gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas, rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This concludes the Heart of the Blessed Lady Perfection of Wisdom, a sūtra of the Great Vehicle.

Translated by the Indian master Vimalamitra and the translator, the monk Rinchen Dé. Revised and finalized by the great translators Gelo, Namkha, and others.

Written on the outer wall of the Bye ma gling shrine of glorious Samyé,
spontaneously accomplished.

Translator's Notes

- The opening phrase "Revised and definitively established" renders the Tibetan editorial colophon marker "འདི་ནི་སྒྲུབ་པ་གསལ་བྱས་པའོ།," which indicates this is a revised and authorized recension of the text. This phrase stands outside the sūtra proper and serves as a scribal or canonical designation.

The Tibetan reads "བུ་རྩེ་གི་རི་དཀར་པོ།" literally as "Vulture Peak Mountain," the standard rendering of Grdhrakūṭa, located near Rājagṛha.

The title "Blessed Lady" renders "bhagavānī," the feminine form of Bhagavān applied here to the Perfection of Wisdom personified as a goddess; this is a distinctive feature of this longer recension of the Heart Sūtra.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text provided, breaking off just as the Blessed One rises from absorption; this is not an error in translation but reflects that the source passage itself is incomplete at this point.

- The closing colophon names Vimalamitra as the Indian paṇḍita and Rinchen Dé as the Tibetan lotsāwa, with a second revision attributed to Gelo and Namkha among others. "Spontaneously accomplished" renders the epithet of Samyé Monastery. The phrase rendered "the Blessed Lady Perfection of Wisdom" reflects the grammatically feminine personification of prajñāpāramitā in the title.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a

human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.